Lesson 35: Evidence and Claims: A Model Essay and When to Cite

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 4: Research and Evidence

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 4.1 Introduction; 4.2 Sample Student Research Essay: Heritage Languages; 4.3 Using Evidence to Support Claims; 4.4 Knowing When to Cite.

In this lesson

You read a student research essay on heritage languages and study how the writer supports her claims with different types of evidence. You learn when a sentence needs a citation, and you write a body paragraph for your research project. Good evidence, correctly cited, makes your writing persuasive and honest.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain why academic writers support claims with evidence and cite their sources.
- Identify five types of evidence in a text.
- Choose evidence from an article for a topic sentence.
- Decide whether a sentence needs a citation.
- Write a body paragraph that combines cited evidence with your own explanation.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
claim	a statement that the writer wants readers to accept; it needs support	Families should keep trying to maintain their mother tongue.
evidence, support	information that shows why a claim is true	facts, statistics, quotations, examples
statistic	a fact that relies on numbers	Roughly 3 in 4 of these English learners speak Spanish.
anecdotal evidence	evidence from personal stories and experience	my cousins in Switzerland
general knowledge	something that everybody knows	Spanish is spoken in many countries.
heritage language	the language of a person's family, often an immigrant family (also: home language, mother tongue)	"Keeping Korean means keeping our roots."

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
According to X, ... / X insists that ...	introduce a source's words or ideas	According to Ruth Lingxin Yan, ...
[ ] and . . .	square brackets show a change to a quotation; an ellipsis shows words left out	"We . . . spen[t] a whole summer in Korea"

Rules and explanations

Why use evidence and cite it?

- Most academic writing uses other texts (books, articles, films) as evidence for **your** argument. Choose the best evidence and connect it smoothly to your own ideas.
- Showing where information comes from makes your writing more persuasive, lets readers check it, and shows **academic honesty**: you do not claim others' ideas as your own.
- A reflective or response essay uses more personal experiences, observations and examples. A research paper relies on quotations, reasons and facts; personal experience only adds to points that your research already supports.

Five types of evidence (the book's examples)

Type	Example
General facts (cited if you learned them through research)	Some parents believe that it is more important to learn the new language of the new country where they live (Brown 31).
Statistics (cited)	More than ten percent of children in the US public school system are not native speakers of English (Mata-McMahon).
Quotations or paraphrases from experts (cited)	Catherine Snow, Professor of Education at Harvard University, insists that "[i]t's ironic ..." (full quotation in the lesson material)
Examples (cited if you learned them through research)	A Korean father, Mr. Rhee, explains that his family "spen[t] a whole summer in Korea" and that his son's Korean "was improved a lot" (qtd. in Kang 435).
Personal experience or observations	the writer's cousins in Switzerland learned Portuguese easily; her niece in the United States understands it but cannot speak it

Citation has two parts

- An **in-text citation**: the author's name (or the title, if there is no author), with a page number if there is one: (Brown 31). "qtd. in" marks words of a person quoted in another source: (qtd. in Brown 33).
- The **Works Cited** page: a detailed list of the sources at the end of the paper (see Lesson 38).

When to cite

You must cite	You do not need to cite
exact words from a source (in quotation marks)	general knowledge: things that everybody knows
a paraphrase of a source	statements that are obviously true
information or ideas from a source that you did not know before your research	anecdotal evidence from your own experience

Be especially careful with numbers and statistics: without a citation, it will look as if you made them up.

> **Psychology note:** Psychology uses APA style: author, year and page, for example (Brown, 2011, p. 31). For words that you found in another source, APA writes "as cited in" instead of "qtd. in": (San Diego et al., as cited in Tran, 2010, p. 261).

Practice

Exercise 1. The model essay. Read "Heritage Languages: the Language of Emotions" by Joana Coelho Silverio (4.2) in the lesson material.

1. Copy her thesis statement.
2. What are the three ways to maintain a heritage language in body paragraphs 1 to 3?
3. Which paragraph presents an opposing view? What evidence does she use to answer it?
4. What does "(qtd. in Brown 33)" after the father's words mean?
5. Why does the example of the Portuguese word *saudade* have no citation?

Exercise 2. Notice this! (4.3) What types of evidence do you see in the example paragraph that begins "On the other hand, unfortunately, some immigrant do not prioritize ..."?

Exercise 3. Which type of evidence? Choose: general fact, statistic, quotation or paraphrase from an expert, example, or personal experience/observation.

1. The prevalence of these students varies greatly across the country, ranging from 0.8% in West Virginia to 19.2% in California.
2. According to Ruth Lingxin Yan, a professor at Nebraska College of Education and Human Sciences, "parents who held the view that heritage language learning was connected to the academic performance of their children ... tended to choose ... bilingual schools" (105).
3. For example, for my cousins that were born in Switzerland, it was easy to learn Portuguese, because they have relatives that live near them.
4. As one of Hyun-Sook Kang's interviewees recalls, "We . . . spen[t] a whole summer in Korea last year. Henry was five years old. . . ." (qtd. in Kang 435).
5. Roughly 3 in 4 of these English learners speak Spanish.

Exercise 4. Try this! Using different types of evidence (4.3). Read "1 in 10 US students are English learners" by Jennifer Mata-McMahon in the lesson material. Topic sentence: "Public schools should help immigrant children to maintain their heritage language."

1. Look for different kinds of evidence for this topic sentence.
2. Paraphrase one fact, with a correct citation.
3. Write down one quotation from an expert or one statistic, with a correct citation.
4. Add a personal experience, observation or example, if you have one.
5. Write a concluding explanation of how this evidence supports the topic sentence.
6. Compare your paragraph with the sample paragraph in the answer key.

Exercise 5. Notice this! (4.4) Read the body paragraph that begins "The most important thing immigrant parents can do is to speak heritage language at home." Which sentences include citations? Why did the writer cite those sentences?

Exercise 6. Try this! Deciding if you should cite (4.4). Should these sentences be cited?

1. More than half of the 6,900 languages in the world will disappear over the next 100 years.
2. It was easy for my cousins who were born in Switzerland to learn Portuguese because there is a large Portuguese community there. In contrast, my niece ... understands almost everything, but she cannot speak Portuguese.
3. Most immigrants feel the need to transmit their language and culture to their children because it is part of their identity.
4. Children of immigrants who are bilingual have better academic performance than children of immigrants who do not know their parents' native language.

Exercise 7. Cite or not? Sentences from a paper on sleep and memory. Should they be cited?

1. Sleep is a basic human need.
2. Before my exams last year, I slept four hours a night and forgot many things that I had studied.
3. In one experiment, students who slept after learning a list of words remembered more of them the next day than students who stayed awake.
4. About one in three adults in the United States does not get enough sleep.
5. A definition of "memory consolidation" copied word for word from OpenStax *Psychology 2e*.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here are five sentences from my draft: [paste]. Does each one need a citation? Why?"
- "Here is my paraphrase of a sentence from the Mata-McMahon article: [paste]. Is it too close to the original? Is the meaning exact?"
- "Play a parent who wants the children to speak only English at home. I will argue for the heritage language with evidence from Joana's essay. After five turns, tell me which evidence worked best."
- "Here is my body paragraph: [paste]. Label each sentence as claim, evidence (which type) or explanation. Is anything missing?"

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each / and stress the words in bold.

1. "Heritage language is the **essence** of who we are," / writes Clara Lee Brown.
2. As one immigrant father explains, / "We need to talk about our **roots** as immigrants. / Keeping Korean means keeping our **roots**."
3. Bilingual people tend to be better at connecting with others / from different ethnic backgrounds and cultures.
4. Without a citation, / it will look as if you just **made** this information **up**!

Writing task

Write one body paragraph of 150 to 220 words for a research paper. Choose a topic sentence (or write your own):

1. Your project: "Getting enough sleep is one of the most effective ways for university students to remember what they study." Use two sources from your annotated bibliography (Lesson 34).
2. The book's topic: "Public schools should help immigrant children to maintain their heritage language." Use the Mata-McMahon article.

Include your claim, at least two types of cited evidence (one paraphrased), personal experience only as extra support (optional), an explanation, a concluding sentence, and a Works Cited (or References) entry for each source.

Self-editing checklist:

- Does my topic sentence make a clear claim?
- Did I use at least two different types of evidence?
- Does every quotation, paraphrase and statistic have a citation?
- Are exact words in quotation marks, and is my paraphrase in my own words with the exact meaning?
- Did I explain how the evidence supports my claim?
- Is there a Works Cited (or References) entry for every source?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- "1 in 10 US students are English learners" by Jennifer Mata-McMahon (the original article, Exercise 4): https://theconversation.com/1-in-10-us-students-are-english-learners-143324

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. "Although there is a loss of heritage language by the second-generation immigrants, families should keep trying to maintain their mother tongue because our language is our identity."
2. Speaking the heritage language at home; bilingual and heritage language schools; being around native speakers (relatives, the community, long stays in the home country).
3. The fifth ("On the other hand ..."): some parents speak the new country's language at home so that their children learn it faster (Brown 31). She answers with a research finding: fluently bilingual second-generation children "performed better on academic tests and had better GPAs" (San Diego et al. qtd. in Tran 261).
4. The words belong to a Korean immigrant father (Nina's father); the writer found them quoted in Clara Lee Brown's article, on page 33.
5. It comes from her own knowledge of her first language (personal experience), not from a source.

Exercise 2 A paraphrase from an expert (also a general fact): Clara Lee Brown claims that some parents think the new language is more important (Brown 31). A quotation from experts reporting a research finding: bilingual children "performed better on academic tests and had better GPAs" (San Diego, Rumbaut & Cornelius qtd. in Tran 261). An observation without a citation: many children refuse to speak their heritage language. The last sentence is the writer's conclusion.

Exercise 3

1. Statistic.
2. Quotation from an expert.
3. Personal experience/observation.
4. Example.
5. Statistic.

Exercise 4

1. Statistics (more than 1 in 10 public school students are English learners; dual-language programs in only 35 states), a general fact (without these programs, English learners tend to stop being fluent in their first language by high school), and research findings on the benefits of bilingualism (connecting with others, solving problems, better jobs, creativity).
2. (example answer) Adults who have kept their first language alongside English are often more employable, and they may be paid more, than adults who have lost it (Mata-McMahon).
3. (example answer) Only 35 states offered dual-language programs, which help children become bilingual (Mata-McMahon).
4. (example answer) My neighbor's son attends a public school with a bilingual program, and he now reads and writes both Arabic and English.
5. (example answer) In other words, schools that support home languages give immigrant children advantages that last into adulthood.

6. The book's sample paragraph (book), after the topic sentence, has four parts:
    - **Fact:** "This is because without support, most immigrant children will lose their mastery of the home language by the time they are in high school (Mata-McMahon)."
    - **Quotation from an expert:** "According to Jennifer McMahon, University of Maryland professor, 'Bilingual people tend to be better at connecting with others ... They are also better at solving problems'."
    - **Personal observation:** a friend's thirteen-year-old son from Peru, who attended a bilingual private school, reads and writes Spanish and English and is very confident with people.
    - **Conclusion:** this opportunity should not be only for families who can pay for private schools; the United States should cultivate the skills of all multilingual children. Corrections: her surname is Mata-McMahon (the book's key says "Jennifer McMahon"; this is a mistake because it leaves out part of her name). The "fact" is also stronger than the article, which says English learners "tend to stop being fluent" without these programs. More exact: "Without dual-language programs, English learners often lose fluency in their first language by high school (Mata-McMahon)."

Exercise 5 Two sentences: "Using the heritage language to communicate at home ... (Guardado)" paraphrases an idea from Guardado; "As an immigrant father explains, 'We need to talk about our roots ...' (qtd. in Brown 33)" uses exact words found in Brown's article. The other sentences are the writer's own ideas and explanations.

Exercise 6 (book)

1. Cite: it is a statistic and a fact. The citation is (Tesch).
2. No citation: this is anecdotal evidence (personal experience). But it cannot be your only support for a point; you also need evidence from your research.
3. No citation: the book's key says it is obviously true. (Be careful with words like *most*: if a reader could ask "How do you know?", find a source.)
4. Cite: this may or may not be true, so you need evidence. The citation is (San Diego, Rumbaut and Cornelius qtd. in Tran 261).

Exercise 7

1. No: general knowledge.
2. No: your own experience (anecdotal evidence), but it can only be extra support.
3. Yes: a research finding that you learned from a source.
4. Yes: a statistic.
5. Yes: exact words go in quotation marks, with a citation.

My notes